With the campaign stretching over several months—remember, Modi was on the road for almost nine months—the ready availability of cash meant that there was no let-up in the intensity of the BJP campaign. The Congress funding began to dry up as the campaign wore on. By the last stage, it had become a one-way street as the BJP campaign reached a crescendo and the Congress became practically invisible.

So, how much did the two main parties actually spend? When I put this question to the two party treasurers, they would not reveal any figure—Piyush Goyal of the BJP at least laughed at the figures I threw at him; Vora of the Congress just stared blankly at me. Election expenses remain notoriously opaque. Only a few business houses have set up official electoral trusts to give money by cheque. Most of the election money is generated through cash-rich businesses like real estate, liquor, stockbroking and mining.

At a rate of around Rs 8 to 10 crore per ‘winnable’ constituency plus other campaign expenses, the BJP had raised anywhere between Rs 4000 to 5000 crore—at least that’s my hunch, though Goyal insists it was much less. The Congress was probably a few thousand crores behind in the race this time. Given the mood in the country, the Congress would have almost certainly still lost badly. Money talks—but it can’t influence a wave election like that of 2014, it can only provide additional momentum. A few years ago, a prominent Congress politician from Andhra is believed to have spent more than Rs 70 crore on a by-election and still lost! As one corporate leader told me, ‘We didn’t decide this election, we only backed the right horse!’

I got a sense of the mood in the business community when in February I made a presentation on likely election scenarios to a group of foreign investors in Mumbai, and placed a clear Modi win as the top possibility. The prospect seemed to enthuse the gathering. ‘If Modi wins, the India story lives,’ said one of them effusively.

One of the investors, though, still seemed troubled. ‘Please tell me, is there any chance of another hung Parliament and a third-front prime minister after the elections?’ Mamata Banerjee had once again announced